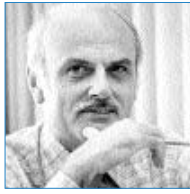




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A Café For The Blind

Text-to-speech software can help open up the world of the Internet to the blind

Mithun Kidambi

As you walk down the seashore, the salty spray lands softly on your face. Unwelcome on a sweltering July afternoon, the same would have evoked a sense of poetry on a better day. You ignore the play of light on the foam, the multitude of reflections and imagery that the sunlight lends to the waves. You ignore it because you can see it.

You'd more want to look at

nature's little ditties if you couldn't see at all.

We've all realised, at some point, how difficult it is to function in the dark. But just to refresh your conscience, imagine sitting in front of a computer with a blindfold across your eyes. Now try to navigate to a link.

You wouldn't be able to without assistance, of course. Let's try voice prompts, or software that reads what's on your screen. The text-to-speech tool is cumbersome, and for those stuck on point-and-

click, it's difficult to navigate from one window or link to the next following voice commands.

But then, isn't it difficult to walk a few steps with a blindfold on? If you throw in a couple of turns there's sure to be a lot of tripping and falling.

It is indeed difficult for us to visualise, if one may use the term, moving around in the real world or in cyberspace without the aid of our eyes. But spare a thought for those who do it every day, and are pretty adept at it.

Imaging Pradeep Ingole

